‘After a while I raised a few difficulties about the Rajput’s move to Yumtso-la, even if the Chinese permitted us to do so. When I pointed out the shortage of snow clothing, I was informed that 6,000 sets had been ordered from Canada. On the question of artillery coverage, I was told that determined infantry do not need artillery. The requirement for porters was settled by a promise to send us all the Border Roads Pioneers from Tawang. Everything seemed to be in the future except the move of the Rajputs, which was to be the next day.’

In a last-ditch effort to salvage the situation, Dalvi suggested a strong patrol be sent out before committing the entire battalion. The corps commander reluctantly agreed and it was decided that 9 Punjab would undertake the task later that day. A patrol commanded by an officer would cross the Nam Ka Chu and occupy Tseng Jong that night. 2 Rajput less Bravo Company would move from their assembly area at first light on 10 October and occupy Tsangle, Muksar and Tseng Jong. The Thagla Ridge would then be occupied from the west and 2 Rajput would clear the Chinese to their east until checked. In the final phase, 1/9 GR would pass through the Rajput positions and clear the Chinese from the entire ridge line while 9 Punjab would advance from the Nam Ka Chu and marry up with the Rajputs and Gorkhas.

CHARGE OF KAUL’S LIGHT BRIGADE (TO DELHI)

At the appointed hour, a fifty-man patrol of 9 Punjab under the command of their Delta Company commander, Major Mahander Singh Chaudhary, made their way along the north bank of the Nam Ka Chu from Tsangle near Bridge 5 to Tseng Jong. Meanwhile, 2 Rajput on the opposite bank was preparing two more crossing points just upstream of Bridge 4; these would be known subsequently as Log and Temporary Bridges. At Tseng Jong, the ground was too rocky and hard for digging, so the men quickly constructed sangars while an LMG (light machine gun) section under Havildar Malkiat Singh was told to dig in at the base of Karpo-la 2 from where he could give enfilade fire (strike the enemy from the flank) if the sangars at Tseng Jong came under attack in the morning. The men worked through the night, preparing whatever defences they could.

Just before first light on 10 October, Malkiat drew Chaudhary’s attention to the direction of Yumtso-la from where he could see a mass of torches descending towards the Punjabis. After a while, the torches were